EL SALVADOR (11 September)

Harvesting of the 2000/01 first season cereal and bean crops continues under normal weather conditions, following an unusually long dry summer spell ("canicula") in July which severely affected the crops in some areas. Particularly affected were the eastern parts of the country, the Department of Santa Ana in the north-west, some areas in the south-western Departments of Ahuachapán and Sonsonate and the western part of the Department of Chalatenango in the north. Production of maize, the main cereal, is thus provisionally forecast at a slightly below average 570 000 tonnes, while that of sorghum is expected at a below-average 145 000 tonnes. By contrast, production of beans, an important staple in the population's diet, is forecast to be average as the bulk of the crop had already been harvested in the main producing areas and the remaining plantings were not affected by the drought. Some localized damage is reported to the paddy crop, but output is nevertheless forecast to be about average. Food assistance, as a component of various reconstruction projects (food for work) is still being distributed in some areas, following hurricane "Mitch" devastating impact at the end of 1998.

Wheat imports in marketing year 2000/01 (July/June) are anticipated to be about 180 000 tonnes, similar to the previous year. Maize imports are forecast to increase from 175 000 tonnes to some 245 000 tonnes to compensate for the drought inflicted production losses. Imports of rice in 2001 marketing year (January/December) should be about 20 000 tonnes, similar to 2000.

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